

manager is quite unique. It is the primary system browsing tool for file management. CD/DVD drives, network folders and more are listed in the left window pane and a simple drag and drop operation makes it possible to take a backup of the files, quite like Windows XP.

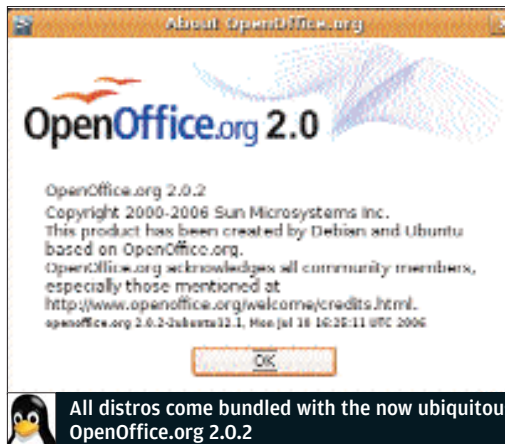
System update

Security is one of those things that is often touted as Linux's core advantage over rival operating systems. To keep the system up to date, one has to often update the system with new patches and bug fixes. Simplifying this update process certainly works in the favour of a novice Linux user. Apart from security, installing new applications also needs to be simple, because installing them is not as simple as a double-click—further dependencies need to be resolved too. The point is, how good were these Linux distros at updating and software installation? Let's figure out.

Ubuntu, being based on Debian, is robust and 'aptitude' still is the preferred application installing tool on the command line. In addition, the Synaptic package manager makes it simpler for a Linux newbie. And finally, the GDebi installer makes installing .deb files a simple double-click affair. Ubuntu also has a software updater, which pops-up messages when new patches or upgrades are available from Ubuntu.

SuSE's YAST has an integrated software updating module. You can select the location from where you want to update from, such as the CD-ROM or the online repository. The YOU (YAST Online Update) makes sure new upgrades and patches are delivered to the system at regular intervals.

Mandriva 2006 comes with a new Smart package manager. Unlike other package managers, Smart differs in the way that it can use different types of packages other than what Mandriva specifically uses—Slackware repository and .deb repositories as well. The original urpmi package manager is still present and is as simple to use as any other packager manager today.



Xandros network is the tool that helps keep the system up to date on the software part. It is simple to use and allows single-click install of new software. We found Xandros approach quite simple, however it is quite reserved in the number of new applications it makes available.

Conclusion

When it comes to Ubuntu, we have just one thing to say—try it, it's fun! The sleek installation, out of the box operation, great package selection, easy to use package management and a fantastic community makes Ubuntu our choice of Linux distro for the masses.

SuSE still remains the evergreen Linux distro that we have known for years. Novell's takeover has simply added more professionalism and the urge to stay ahead of the competition is bound to grow. However, SuSE still has to work on its hardware compatibility list—it's not perfect yet. We recommend SuSE to Linux fans who want to try out a lot of applications.

Fedora Core 5, probably the oldest community in the Linux world, still holds its own, especially in India where 'RedHat' is synonymous with Linux. Brilliant hardware detection, a dedicated community and a blinding legacy is what gives Fedora its fair share of dedicated users. There is nothing wrong with this distro; it's just that it was left behind in making the necessary cosmetic facelifts that other distros successfully pulled out at the right time.

Mandriva 2006, practically speaking, doesn't have anything wrong with it, but we don't see the point in coughing up money for it. We'd rather opt for Ubuntu, which is free, or pay for SuSE—Novell is well-settled here in India, so support will be good; we can't say the same for Mandriva.

Xandros was a brilliant concept when it first came out, a 'Windows-like Linux'. However, if Ubuntu continues at this pace, we don't see the need for a Windows clone increasing. Of course, we're not criticising the brilliant work done by Xandros, because it achieves nearly everything it originally set out to do.

Finally...

Is Linux ready for the desktop? The level of piracy in India means that for most users, Windows is also 'free'. With an increasing level of security measures being added in Microsoft software, soon you might find yourself forced to either pay up to legally use Windows, or find other free alternatives. But will you be ready?

We suggest you try Linux and decide for yourself. Remember, Linux does not work as well out of the box as other OSes, but you may find yourself liking the power to customise everything. ■

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